



History makers: Kamil Semeniuk (No. 16) of Sir Sicoma Perugia, which became just the third club in the tournament's history, apart from Sada and Trentino Volley, to successfully defend the title. SUDHAKARAJAIN

Armas. The final practice session before the match saw two contrasting training patterns. While the Perugia players were kicking the ball towards each other, Minas' trainers were offering tips and helping the players stretch in sync. Then came the last spike practice for the tournament, where balls flew all over the stadium with the audience cheering and hitting the ball away every time it came close to them.

To get a better view of their favourite players, the audience resorted to sitting on the floor in the stand, and they were not disappointed as the Italian and Brazilian outfits provided ample entertainment. In less than an hour and a half after the whistle that started the final between Perugia and Minas, the winner was decided. With a 25-13, 25-21, 25-19 clean victory, Perugia became just the third

club in the tournament's history, apart from Sada (winner: 2013, 2015, 2016, 2021) and Trentino Volley (winner: 2009, 2010, 2011, 2012), to successfully defend the title.

According to Minas' captain Lucas Loh, despite the team having a chance to get ahead of Perugia in the second set, they could not make the most of it. "This (the points Perugia earned back) is all in their service and the potential to get back in the game. Because of their service, we couldn't do that (create a lead and win the set)," he said.

Another setback for the Brazilian outfit was the absence of Santos on the court. "Isac is one of our most important spikers, who exerts immense pressure on the opposition and spikes high and hard. So (his absence) was felt. However, there is no excuse for us this time as we had good players that we could bank on.

And we did a good job in the semifinal," said Loh.

Plotnytskyi, the most valuable player of the tournament and the best outside hitter, was glad that the four consecutive days of hustle and back-to-back games without a day's break had finally come to a halt. However, the Ukrainian was pleased to note that the team achieved the goal that it worked towards.

"We are happy that we won — it was our goal. But our main goal was to make our team stronger and grow as the tournament progressed, as we had to play for four continuous days with different food, gym and other changes. But we are professionals, so we had to be ready for this," said the 26-year-old.

In the end, Sicoma did end up fulfilling its motto and realising 'The Indian Dream' and hopes to replicate the same in 2024.